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Product Improvement Challenge

The Product Improvement Challenge is a hands-on exercise in product thinking. The goal isn't just to suggest a cool feature, but to dive deep into a real-world product, diagnose a genuine pain point, and design a solution that is both creative and technically feasible.

My Approach:

To tackle this, I've moved beyond surface-level UI/UX complaints. Instead, I've applied a PM-first mindset by:

- **Deconstructing User Journeys:** Analyzing how different personas (from casual browsers to personality enthusiasts) interact with the app.
- **Spotting the Friction:** Identifying exactly where users feel frustrated or hit a dead end.
- **Analyzing Constraints:** Acknowledging the technical and business boundaries that the app operates within.
- **Defining Success:** Determining the specific metrics that will prove if this improvement actually works.

Product Overview

What is 'Pdb app'?

PDB (Personality Database) is a unique space where psychology meets community. While the platform has a dedicated user base, there are specific friction points in the user journey that hinder growth and engagement. This document identifies a high-impact problem area and proposes a strategic solution to make the PDB experience more seamless for its diverse global community. It's a safe place for deep thinkers and typology enthusiasts who want to understand the "why" behind human behaviour.

The Niche Advantage

Unlike horizontal social giants, PDB owns a specific intellectual sanctuary. It doesn't try to be everything for everyone; instead, it provides a high-density environment for a specific psychographic: introverts, analytical minds, and fans of character study. By focusing on typology rather than just profiles, PDB has built a community that values intellectual depth over surface-level interaction.

Why I chose Pdb App

When we look at the saturated market of social and dating apps, it is easy to get lost in the noise of bots, high barriers to entry, and superficial swiping. My decision to focus on PDB (Personality Database) stems from how it fundamentally disrupts the traditional connection model.

Here is why this platform stands out:

- **Authentic Human Connection over Bots:** Unlike many mainstream competitors, PDB maintains a remarkably high ratio of genuine, "sane" users. The community isn't driven by a high-pressure dating mindset; it is driven by curiosity and shared interests.
- **Accessibility from Day One:** On most platforms, talking to a new person feels like an uphill battle. PDB removes those gatekeepers, allowing users to engage, comment, and build friendships starting the very first hour they sign up.
- **The Wonder Chat Innovation:** This feature is a game-changer for privacy and discovery. It allows you to jump into conversations based on vibes and thoughts alone—without the bias of identities or profile pictures—until a real connection is formed.
- **A Unique Psychological Niche:** By centering the experience around MBTI, Enneagram, and other personality frameworks, the app provides a common language for self-discovery. It makes the complex task of understanding ourselves and others significantly easier.

In a world of swipe-left culture, PDB App as a Hidden Gem offers a safe space where personality actually takes center stage.

The Challenge

Despite its unique value, PDB faces critical friction points. Complexity in the voting system and navigation hurdles often stall the user journey. This case study identifies a high-impact problem area and proposes a solution to bridge the gap between PDB's deep data and its daily usability.

User Research & Pain Points

To understand the gap between PDB's potential and its current state, I analyzed user feedbacks from community forums, app store reviews, and active users of the app. The goal was to move past 'bad UI' complaints and find the specific friction points that cause users to close the app, and surprisingly I found some interesting pain points.

Pain Point List:

1. Personalized Dashboard & No Daily Hook

- Users don't have any clear daily hook or personalized space (dashboard/feed) that encourages them to come back regularly; they just browse profiles or random chats once and then don't return.
- There's no "this is tailored for me" area (e.g., type-insights, reflection prompts, or a feed of relevant people/data), so the app feels episodic, not habitual.

2. Laggy and Buggy UI with Performance Issues

- The app feels slow and laggy when scrolling through profiles or character lists, making basic navigation frustrating.
- Users report that their phone gets hot and the app drains battery quickly, implying background or rendering inefficiencies.
- The UI sometimes auto-opens random chats with strangers and shows a persistent "online strangers" tab that can't be closed, adding visual noise and confusion.

3. Weak Onboarding For a Certain Personality Type

- The app assumes users already know and trust their exact MBTI/Enneagram type and forces them into a rigid, argument-heavy typology identity before they are ready, which pushes away casual explorers and fuels community toxicity.

4. Over-Monetization That Kills Early-Stage Retention

- Premium prompts and intrusive full-screen ads pop up on almost every action, often hiding features or profiles behind pay-walls, which makes early-stage users feel exploited instead of nurtured.
- This pattern discourages users from exploring the app freely, leading them to uninstall before they experience real value.

5. Reaching Out and Engaging the Community Feels Hard

- Users complain that the app dumps them into random chats or "online strangers" tabs instead of letting them easily join or discover structured communities, groups, or topic-based circles.
- There's no clear way to find or follow niche communities (e.g., "INFJ creators", "MBTI-curious beginners"), so community discovery feels fragmented and accidental rather than intentional.

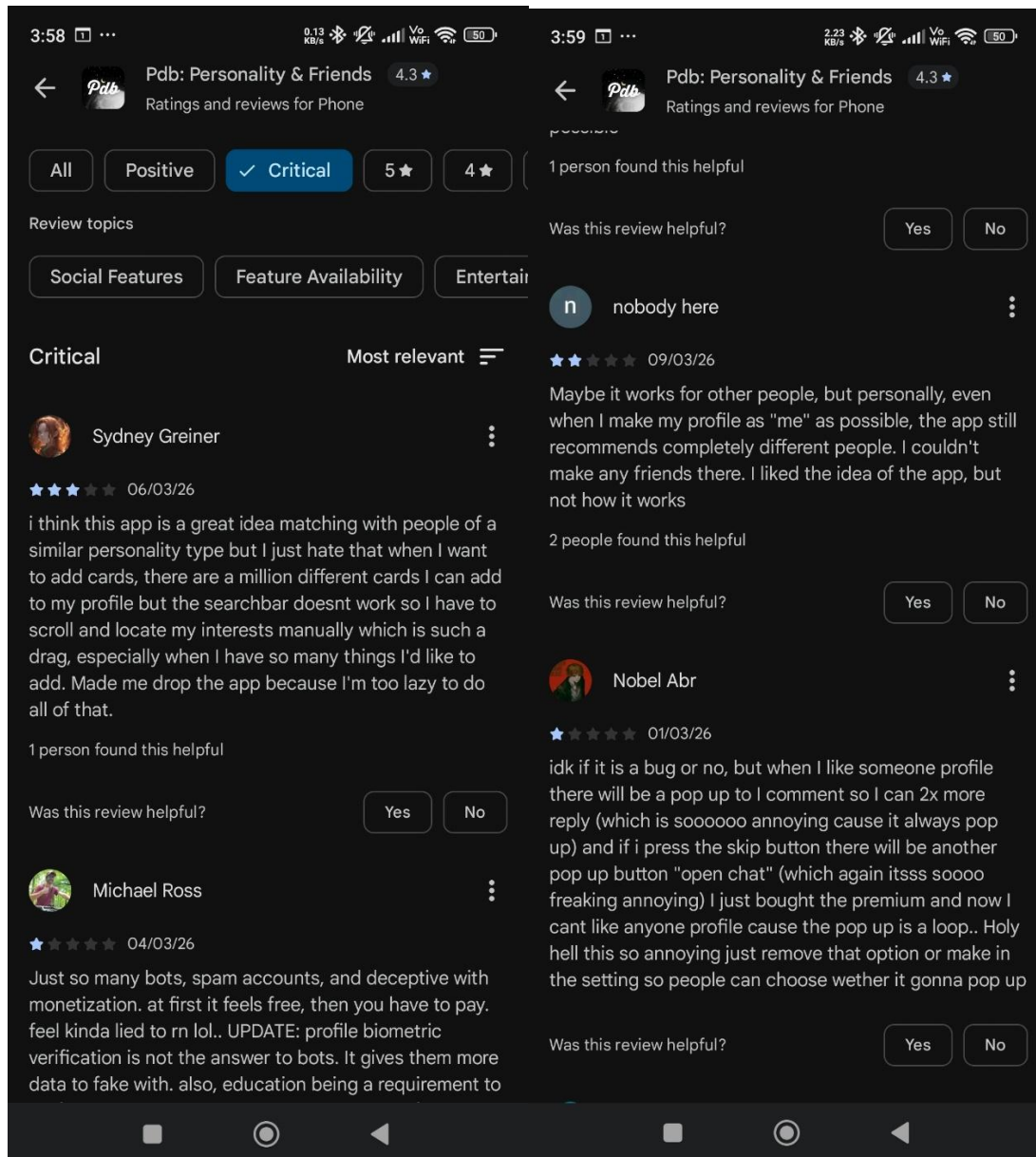
6. Missing Easy Profile Creation and Self-Expression

- Users explicitly say they do not see an option to create a character profile and that there is no easy place to edit or update their personality type or bio.
- The developers themselves acknowledge that the ability to enter and edit character profiles is still being developed, which limits how users can express and refine their identity inside the app.

Impact:

Metric/business impact	Pain point causing it
Early-stage churn	Laggy and buggy UI, over-monetization, weak onboarding
30-day retention problem	Missing personalized dashboard / habit loop
Session depth and DAU	Laggy UI, random chats, unclosable tabs, no community feed
Community engagement	Hard to discover and join topic-based groups and circles
Profile completion rate	Missing easy profile creation and type-editing
Premium conversion rate	Over-monetization and poor early-experience quality
Word-of-mouth growth	Weak onboarding, aggressive ads, negative community perception

Proof and Validations:



👤 by Eeyoreisbae

I don't mind the added features for socializing, but this used to be a database where you could easily search for types and it has become a social media site. Please just put back the feature to filter for multiple types. I want to find characters who are specific combinations (entp 5 for example) and there's no way to filter for that anymore. I don't understand why they got rid of a feature they already had. Not only that but the website has been changed too, it's not just PdbApp . Please put it back.

revealing ages



👤 by Lee™

suddenly making the ages of your 18+ users public without permission - with NO option to hide it - is so disturbing. don't bother with PdbApp if you place any value in trust or privacy. i'd recommend at least not putting in any of your real information, seeing as they clearly can't be trusted with it. i've deleted my account, and i'd highly suggest doing the same if you're considering it.

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👤 by 2cutelivi

I would give zero stars if I could. I've downloaded PdbApp multiple times to try and use it but every time it opens a blurred screen of my homescreen, and then closes itself out. When you try to use the website you can't even use it for a minute before getting hounded with popups saying to get PdbApp . It's just unusable and I used to love using this website to find out my personality characters but now I can't. I've tried everything to try and use it but it's impossible. Might be an issue with my phone but it's genuinely annoying.

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The website on desktop is fine. If you try to access the website on mobile, it has removed functionality, and it's broken and ridden with pop-ups that force you to download PdbApp constantly.

When you download PdbApp , it has removed functionality from the website. There's NO WAY TO FILTER categories by type, enneagram, etc. That's literally the whole point of this site. Instead, the mobile app forces you to make an account to participate in the "social media" aspect of the platform, which is completely broken and uninteresting. Quit forcing these horrible tacked on social media features, nobody wants it, nobody wants to talk to weirdos, just let me filter and search!

Too many ads and links to unwanted services



👤 by Price Gougers

PdbApp is trying to be too many things at once. I think you guys should focus on why people want to use it (to analyze their favorite characters) instead of forcing people into some pseudo tinder and re directing everytime a user lands on the page. The website even forces you to download PdbApp . There are better ways to monetize if that is your goal, cornering in users who were used to interacting with this service one way and then completely changing it and cornering us into paying is just going to drive users away. I deleted PdbApp because it is useless at this point.

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disappointment to what it previously was



👤 by Anthrozpjobia

I've used PDB since 2019. I remember when Lettuce was the owner and we actually talked once. It was an easy, simple website to look up mbti types of characters that you like and have some fun off topic discussions on the aptly named "Fun Board".

It all went downhill when the website went through a redesign in October a few years ago. It became more "modern and sleek" but lost all the charm it originally had as a simple website.

Now it's an app and it's an absolute hellhole. "Just don't use PdbApp" if I'm on mobile, I can't look up a character on the website without being forced to download PdbApp. If I'm on desktop, I can't change my profile picture, there's ads that practically break the site, and the notifications don't work. Some stupid AI bots reply to every post I make even not on PdbApp and on PdbApp I am constantly bombarded with ads and requests for me to upgrade to premium so I can see who viewed my profile, which I do not care about in the slightest.

I literally just want to look up MBTI types of characters I like. This shouldn't be that hard. Stick to your original purpose for f's sake.

👤 by Jason Laurent Jerssenelli

PdbApp has downgraded terribly. It used to be a simple site where people could discuss MBTI, and it used to be much easier to navigate whether you were talking about a trait, character, concept, franchise, etc. However, with this new money-grubbing update, every feature in PdbApp has become a paid feature. I mean, come on! The one simple feature PdbApp was used for, which is searching MBTI, you can't even be done anymore without paying because PdbApp doesn't show you the full results unless you pay for premium or watch an ad. And whenever I try to watch an ad, it doesn't even display anything. I appreciate how they're trying to make PdbApp more social, but it's super hard to navigate and edit your profile, let alone even access your chats because you can't even open them without paying.

went downhill



👤 by Dilate If Je

first of all, why is PdbApp exposing my location in my about me when I don't even have location services allowed? even worse, I can't remove the location from my bio making my privacy extremely at risk. PdbApp used to be somewhat usable, but now it's a lame knock-off of a dating app when quite literally nobody asked for that. half of the features are locked behind a paywall and you can't even DM new people without paying. bring the old app back and maybe I'll consider redownloading, but there's so many issues that it's become intolerable. deleting my account seems like the only solution to removing my location, a shame I have no other choice since you made it virtually impossible to remove it any other way.

 Wizzup - Make new friends BY CANDYLABS LTD SOCIAL NETWORKING Free PDB VS WIZZUP 4.1 / 0 YES / - YES / NO FREE / FREE SCORE ADS IN-APP PURCHASE PRICE	 Whipd - Make New Friends WHIP YOUR WORLD! SOCIAL NETWORKING Free PDB VS WHIPD 4.1 / 4.2 YES / YES YES / YES FREE / FREE SCORE ADS IN-APP PURCHASE PRICE	 SpaceHey Mobile THE RETRO SOCIAL NETWORK. SOCIAL NETWORKING Free PDB VS SPACEHEY MO... 4.1 / 4.3 YES / NO YES / NO FREE / FREE SCORE ADS IN-APP PURCHASE PRICE	 Buzz - Make friends SWIPE, MEET & CHAT REAL PEOPLE SOCIAL NETWORKING Free PDB VS BUZZ 4.1 / 4.5 YES / NO YES / YES FREE / FREE SCORE ADS IN-APP PURCHASE PRICE
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Wasn't satisfied



by Mariag2000

I was excited to see PdbApp and I thought maybe PdbApp was going to show more details on the characters and why their personality works the way it does. Instead it's just a bunch of comment section where people debate with not the best points on why characters are their personality base. I think it's especially unfair for the characters who are a certain personality and people have good points but they change them because there's more of a bigger population towards a certain personality. At the end of the day the points people make don't matter because different personalities have different amounts of people who have that personality and definitely some more than others so the characters are bound to get changed whether people agree or disagree. I think it was better off just a website rather than an actual app. I enjoyed to see what characters I could relate to and the personalities we have but now I rarely have any characters to look at and some other people can agree also and it's frustrating so I'm just deleting PdbApp from now on.

Links:

<https://justuseapp.com/en/app/1614566357/pdb-the-personality-database/reviews>

https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=pdb.app&hl=en_IN

<https://appshunter.io/ios/app/1614566357/reviews>

Persona Based User Stories

Persona 1 – New MBTI Curious User (Riya, 20, college, just exploring)

- As a user who is new to personality types, I want an onboarding that explains MBTI and Enneagram in a simple way without forcing me into a strict label, so I can explore without feeling pressured or judged.
- As a user who wants to try out Pdb, I want to create a basic profile and character page in a clear, easy place, so I do not have to search for hidden options or assume the app is incomplete.

Persona 2 – Daily User Who Likes Deep Chats (Arjun, 23, uses it often)

- As a user who opens Pdb almost every day, I want a personalized dashboard that shows my recent chats, favourite people, and a short daily reflection or type-related tip, so I feel there is something new and meaningful each time I open the app.
- As a user who values real conversations, I want the app to stop auto-opening random chats and remove the unclosable online strangers tab, so I can focus on the people I actually want to talk to instead of feeling spammed.

Persona 3 – Casual Browser (Priya, 25, checks once in a while)

- As a user who uses Pdb only occasionally, I want the app to scroll smoothly and load profiles and characters quickly, so I do not get annoyed by lag or slow loading and give up on exploring.
- As a user who browses just for fun, I want fewer full-screen ads and less constant pushing of premium, so I can look at profiles and chats without feeling like the app is more focused on selling than on serving me.

Persona 4 – Community-Focused User (Vikram, 28, likes groups and discussions)

- As a user who wants to join topic-based circles, I want an easy way to discover and join communities such as INFJ creators, MBTI beginners, or type-specific groups, so I can reach out to people who share my interests instead of only getting random strangers.
- As a user who enjoys posts and discussions, I want the app to feel more like a feed of posts and topics and less like a random chat stream, so I can follow content and people instead of just getting pushed into random DMs.

Persona 5 – Free User Not Ready to Pay (Ananya, 22, budget-conscious)

- As a user who is not ready to pay for premium, I want to access core features like editing my profile, viewing basic chat history, and updating my type without them being blocked by ads or pay-walls, so I can decide later if premium is worth it.
- As a user who dislikes aggressive monetization, I want the app to reduce the number of pop-up premium prompts and full-screen ads, so I do not feel like the app is trying to sell me constantly instead of giving me a good experience.

Solution

Problem area	Solutions
Daily habit / engagement is weak	Introducing a daily fact-based check-in where the app shows 3 short, beginner-friendly points about MBTI, Enneagram, or related topics. In return, the user earns a small amount of in-app coins. This creates a light daily habit and encourages repeat visits.
Users who don't know MBTI/Enneagram feel confused at onboarding	At onboarding, ask the user if they know their MBTI/Enneagram or similar. If they say no , launch an AI-powered personality assistant that asks a short set of questions and suggests a likely MBTI/Enneagram type with a confidence score. If the user disagrees, the assistant asks a few more questions and refines the recommendation. This helps new users understand their type without pressure.
No clear dashboard or personalized space	Adding a profile dashboard that shows: the user's feed, their best connections, MBTI/Enneagram types they tend to get along with, and a small section for appreciation/achievements (e.g., "Most helpful in chats", "Active community member"). This gives a reason to open the app daily and builds a sense of progress.
Laggy and buggy UI (scrolling, chat toggles, search)	Fix lags and bugs in scrolling through profiles, switching between chats, and searching messages. Optimize the layout and loading behaviour so basic navigation feels smooth and fast. This reduces friction and increases session depth.
Over-monetization and intrusive ads	Serve ads based on user usage patterns instead of showing them to everyone at every step. New users for their early days see fewer or no

Problem area	Solutions
	premium ads; only more engaged users see targeted offers. This keeps monetization while reducing early-stage churn and frustration.
Community and group discovery is hard	Let users create private or public groups around topics (e.g., specific MBTI types, hobbies, cities). Add a search bar and allow sharing group links. This makes it easier to find and join communities, boosting engagement and retention.
Habit-loop and retention around personality learning	Add AI-personalized daily tips to the dashboard. The app shows a short tip each day, tailored to the user's MBTI/Enneagram and how they used the app recently. Tips help users grow better with relations, keep them coming back, and strengthen the AI-powered learning path.
Premium trust and conversion is low	Add a 14-day free trial for the core premium features with clear 'cancel anytime' transparency. Users can experience the value without fear of hidden charges, which improves trust, word-of-mouth, and long-term conversion.

Future Implements (Additional)

- Introducing Themes, some for free users and some for premium users also coins can be used there
- Changing 3 screen based bottom navigation bar into 5 Screen Bottom Navigation bar with the middle Chat Screen as a constant floating tab Button
- Introducing AI Chatbot to ask about whereabouts and engage with
- Adding option for capturing video too and sending one time photo / video option in chat in functional requirement
- Enhancing accuracy in translations for enhancing international chat experience

Functional & Non-Functional Requirements

Functional Requirements (What the app must DO)

Feature area	Functional requirement
Onboarding and MBTI/Enneagram suggestion	New users see a choice at onboarding: “Do you know your MBTI/Enneagram?” If they say no, trigger an AI-powered personality assistant that asks a short questionnaire and suggests a likely type with a confidence score.
Type confirmation and refinement	After the AI-powered suggestion, the user can accept or reject. If rejected, the assistant asks a few more questions and refines the recommendation, showing alternative types.
Daily check-in and coins	The app shows a daily fact-based check-in screen with 3 short points about MBTI/Enneagram or related topics. Completing the check-in rewards the user with in-app coins.
Personalized dashboard	The dashboard displays: user’s feed, best connections, compatible MBTI/Enneagram types, and small achievements/appreciation labels (e.g., “Active community member”).
AI-personalized daily tips	The app shows an AI-personalized daily tip each day, tailored to the user’s MBTI/Enneagram and recent activity (e.g., chat behaviour, group joins).
Chat and media in chat	Users can send one-time photos and videos in chat. The app also supports normal text messages and allows the sender to choose whether the photo/video disappears after being viewed once. The app can record and send short video messages directly from the chat screen.
Fix lags and bugs	The app must scroll smoothly through profiles and character lists, open and close chats without lag, and search messages in chat without freezing or long loading.

Feature area	Functional requirement
Smart ad placement	The app must show ads based on user usage patterns (e.g., new users see fewer ads, engaged users see more targeted offers). Premium prompts must respect user context and frequency limits.
Groups and communities	Users must be able to create private or public groups, search for groups by name or topic, and share invite links. The UI must clearly show group membership and recent activity.
Free trial for premium	The app must offer a 14-day free trial for core premium features with a clear cancellation option and no hidden charges. The system must correctly track trial end and downgrade behaviour.

Non-Functional Requirements (How the app should behave)

Area	Non-functional requirement
Performance and responsiveness	The app must scroll through profiles and chats smoothly, with minimal lag or jank. Chat toggles and search must respond within a few hundred milliseconds on mid-range devices.
Stability and reliability	The app must not crash or freeze during normal use (scrolling, opening chats, sending messages, viewing profiles). Bugs affecting messaging or onboarding must be fixed on priority.
Translation quality	Machine translations (for messages, group posts, or tips) must be enhanced to increase accuracy and clarity, especially for shorter phrases and personality-related terms.
Scalability	The backend and chat infrastructure must support a growing number of users and chats without obvious slowdowns during peak usage times.
Maintainability	Code and AI models (for personality assistant and daily tips) must be modular and well-documented so new features can be added without breaking core flows.

Area	Non-functional requirement
Security and privacy	User data (messages, profile, type answers, media) must be stored and transmitted securely. One-time media must be encrypted in transit and deleted from receivers' devices after viewing, where possible.
Usability and UX	The UI must remain simple and intuitive, avoiding confusing layouts. Key actions (onboarding, sending messages, creating groups, managing ads) must be reachable in 1–3 taps.
Localization and language support	The app must support multiple languages cleanly, with proper layout and spacing, and translation improvements must be tracked via user feedback.
AI model behaviour	The AI-powered personality assistant and AI-personalized tips must produce consistent, non-offensive, and non-biased outputs. The system must log and monitor for edge-case bad suggestions.

Prototype

I used Replit to make the Prototype though it was a hard job still I tried my best to make it to that level under the given limit of free credits. The main Features to show was:

- To show the change of Bottom Navigation Tab from 3 tab to 5 tab switcher
- Cutting down the clicks required for exploring groups and communities
- Helping new users with onboarding using AI powered personality assistant
- New 'Themes' Feature to engage users
- New Profile Tab that has customizations and some AI features
- One time View Photo and Video also the new record video feature within a chat helpful for Users who are engaged in conversation more

Link:

[Pdb App Website link](#)

Why Pdb App Should Consider The Solutions

The proposed solutions are expected to move the following key metrics in a positive direction, with these values treated as approximate, **close-call estimates** rather than guaranteed outcomes:

- 30-day retention: +20–30%
- Daily active users (DAU): +15–25%
- Session depth / time in app: +20–30%
- Day-1 retention: +10–15%
- Onboarding completion: +15–20%
- Premium trial sign-up rate: +10–15%
- Community engagement (groups, chats): +20–30%
- Negative reviews / churn from UI issues: –10–15%

A large, horizontal, irregular splash of teal and blue watercolor paint, with darker blue in the center and lighter teal towards the edges, set against a white background.

Thank You